Pat Nixon told Nancy, “Without Camp David, you’ll go stir crazy.” Now I can understand what she meant.

As president, the days I hated most were those with nonstop meetings, one after another, with no time in between to collect my thoughts, and with me scheduled to make remarks or give a short speech at each of them. The days I liked best were those Fridays when I could break away a little early, about three or three thirty, and take off for Camp David.

The president’s home at Camp David, called Aspen, is a beautiful rustic house with beamed ceilings, wood-paneled walls, and big windows that look out at the forest. Just as we did at Rancho del Cielo, Nancy and I experienced a sense of liberation at Camp David that we never found in Washington. Because the perimeter was guarded, we could just open a door and take a walk. That’s a freedom, incidentally, that you don’t fully appreciate until you’ve lost it.

Lyndon Johnson, I’m told, found psychological relief from the isolation of the White House by getting in his Lincoln convertible and driving it at high speed near his ranch in Texas. Once he was pulled over for speeding and the traffic officer came up to his car, realized the driver was the president of the United States, and said, “Oh, my God almighty,” to which Lyndon replied, “And don’t you forget it.” Somebody told me another story about Lyndon that took place out on the South Lawn of the White House. As he was getting ready to leave on a trip, he mistakenly started walking toward the wrong helicopter. A Secret Service man caught up with him and said, “Mr. President, that is your helicopter over there.” Lyndon turned around and said, “Son, they’re *all* my helicopters.”

I usually took a pile of homework and made my weekly radio broadcast during our weekends at Camp David. But there was almost always time to relax in front of a fire with